

South Africa squad



Laura Wolvaardt (c), Tazmin Brits, Nadine de Klerk, Annerie Dercksen, Shabnim Ismail, Sinalo Jafta, Marizanne Kapp, Ayabonga Khaka, Sune Luus, Karabo Meso, Nonkululeko Mlaba, Kayla Reyneke, Tumi Sekhukhune, Chloe Tryon, Dane van Niekerk



Veteran boost: Shabnim Ismail (left) is a surprise inclusion in South Africa's T20 World Cup squad as the Proteas aim to go one better than their finish in the 2024 edition. GETTY IMAGES

and Lea Tahuu carried New Zealand to its maiden T20 crown. In the ODI showpiece nearly a year later, the Proteas made India sweat in the final but still fell short. There were not as many tears as before in the dugout. This side had grown accustomed to stumbling at the final hurdle and seemed more accepting than agitated by the outcome.

As fireworks lit up Navi Mumbai and India was crowned champion with much fanfare, then South African batting coach Baakier Abrahams came up to this reporter and exclaimed: "We've tried so hard to get it (the trophy). Maybe they just wanted it more!"

Cut to the present. A day later than intended, the Proteas management announced their team for the 2026 edition. Among the names read out by the convenor of

selectors, Clinton du Preez, were Shabnim and Dane.

Trump card

At 37, Shabnim shows no signs of slowing down. Since her retirement in 2023, she has featured in 92 T20s and remains a regular face in franchise leagues around the world, including the Women's Premier League.

She played a crucial role in Mumbai Indians winning the 2025 title, the club's second. She also regularly slotted back into her domestic sides, with her searing pace still confounding batters across competitions. Months after her retirement, she clocked the fastest delivery in the history of the women's game, a 132 kmph scorcher.

A video released by Cricket South Africa shows her walking into frame at a training ground and sitting down before saying, "Hi! Guess who's back!" with the widest smile anyone would have seen on her face recently, doing a remarkable job of masking the angst lingering from 2023.

"The loss to Australia was a bitter

pill to swallow," Shabnim said in a video on CSA's socials. "We've done the hard yards throughout and made multiple finals. It's all about that one element, and I don't think it's a skill issue. It's more the mental part. I've been seeing some of the games and the finals that the girls have made. I don't think this team really needs me, but it's nice to be back and help this side win the World Cup. If we do, I'll be saying happy retirement after that."

Shabnim's return could also ease the burden on Marizanne Kapp. Her all-round utility to the side often leaves too much of the rescue work resting on her shoulders. Frequent niggles have forced the management to handle her workload with extreme caution.

While Kapp now shares new-ball duties with the likes of Ayabonga Khaka and Tumi Sekhukhune, no pairing has come close to matching the intimidation factor of Kapp and Shabnim. South Africa will count heavily on that combination, especially in England's seam-friendly conditions.